

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Easy-Medium Misuse risk: Medium

WHY IT WORKS

In group settings, expressing agreement first establishes you as collaborative rather than contrarian — this earns more credibility when your disagreement lands. Group dynamics are more sensitive to tone than a one-on-one exchange.

WHAT IT IS (AND ISN'T)

- Not softening for its own sake — the agreement is real information, not anaesthetic before the needle.
- Not conceding the argument — you name shared ground precisely so the disagreement can be sharper, not weaker.
- It is sequencing: genuine common ground stated first, so the difference lands as collaboration rather than combat.

THE PAYOFF

How it lands: Disagreeing with them never feels like being attacked — so people actually listen to the disagreement.

Principle: People weigh a challenge by whether the challenger seems with them or against them — establish 'with' first and the challenge gets a fair hearing.

What you gain

- Disagreements that get engaged with instead of defended against
- A reputation as constructive rather than contrarian
- Negotiations that stay collaborative under real difference
- Influence with people senior enough to dismiss you
- Sharper debates — the real difference gets isolated quickly

Why most people fail at it

- They skip the agreement entirely and trigger defence before the argument starts.
- They manufacture agreement they do not feel, and it reads as technique.
- They spend so long agreeing that the disagreement never clearly arrives.
- They use 'I agree, but' as a verbal tic, which trains people to brace at 'I agree'.

CORE FORMULA

State what you share -> Build the common ground -> Then diverge clearly

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before presenting your counter-argument, name one specific thing you agree with in their position. Then state your difference.

BEST FOR

- Conversations where the relationship matters as much as the outcome
- Negotiations and collaborative problem-solving
- Presenting alternative views without triggering defensiveness
- Building trust while disagreeing

METHOD, STEP BY STEP

1. Share — State what you genuinely share

Find the point in their position you actually agree with — the goal, a fact, a value — and say it first. If you cannot find one, do not invent one; say you are starting from different places instead.

Hollow: 'I totally hear you, but...'

Specific: 'You are right that support tickets doubled — that is real.'

2. Build — Build the common ground

Spend a sentence making the agreement concrete enough that they recognise it as their own position. This is what separates genuine common ground from a rhetorical warm-up.

Rushed: 'Sure, same goal, obviously. Anyway, here is the problem.'

Built: 'We both want launch before the trade show, and neither of us will ship something broken to get there.'

3. Diverge — Then diverge clearly

Mark the turn explicitly and state your difference at full strength. The shared ground earns you the right to be direct — use it.

Buried: '...so, yes, mostly aligned, just some small thoughts, no big deal.'

Clear: 'Where I differ: two weeks of testing is not enough, and I would push the date.'

FIELD TIP

Agree specifically or do not bother.

'I hear you, but...' is not agreement — it is a queue for your turn to speak, and everyone knows it. Name the specific point of their argument you genuinely accept, and the disagreement that follows inherits its credibility.

Situation: A colleague proposes a rollout plan you think is too fast.

Don't: 'Yeah, I agree with a lot of that, but honestly the timeline is fantasy.'

Do: **'The phasing logic is right — pilot first, then scale. My worry is only the gap between phases.'**

PHRASE BANK

Shared Ground · Naming what you have in common

- "We are both trying to solve the same problem."
- "We agree on the goal — we differ on the method."
- "I share the concern — I just see a different solution."
- "The outcome we both want is the same."
- "We both want this to work."
- "The principle behind what you are saying is one I agree with."
- "We are on the same side here."
- "I am not arguing against your goal — I am arguing for a different path."

Disagreement Bridge · Pivoting to the difference

- "Where I diverge is on the approach."
- "The part I see differently is how to get there."
- "My concern is specifically about the method, not the aim."
- "I agree with the destination — I question the route."
- "The difference is a narrow but important one."

Warm Common Ground · Differences inside close relationships

- "I am on your side in this — I just see one part differently."
- "Before anything else: I understand why this matters to you, and it matters to me too."
- "We want the same thing for the kids — where we differ is how to get there."
- "None of this changes how much I value what you are doing."
- "I agree with your instinct. It is the plan I want to push on."
- "You and I are after the same future — this is only about the route."

Structured Agreement · Precise common ground in work settings

- "Let me start with where the proposal is right — because most of it is."
- "I agree with the problem statement and two of the three recommendations."
- "There is a lot of common ground here, so let me be precise about the one gap."
- "The analysis is sound — my challenge is only to the conclusion drawn from it."
- "I support the direction. I want to stress-test one assumption before we commit."
- "We agree on the goal and the budget. The open question is sequencing."

Agreement Under Fire · Granting the premise before the challenge

- "You are right that the risk is real — and that is exactly why I favour the other option."
- "I grant the premise fully. It is the conclusion I cannot follow you to."
- "We agree this decision is critical — which is why I cannot stay quiet on this point."
- "I accept every fact you have laid out. My disagreement is about what they mean."
- "We want the same result for this company. On this decision, I believe you are wrong."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Launching immediately into your counter-position
Better: Before I disagree — we do agree on X.
Best: Name one specific, genuine shared goal or value before stating the difference.
2. Weak: Manufactured agreement that sounds insincere
Better: I can see we have some common ground.
Best: Specific, true agreement that both parties recognise as real.
3. Weak: Agreeing on everything and then failing to disagree
Better: I have one concern with the approach.
Best: Clear shared ground, clear transition, clear statement of difference.

DECISION TREE

If You disagree but want to keep a collaborative tone

Build the shared ground first. Then name the difference.

"We both want this to succeed. Where I see it differently is on the approach."

If The other person is treating you as an adversary

Name the shared goal explicitly to reframe the dynamic.

"We are solving for the same thing — I want to make sure we are not arguing against each other."

If You cannot find genuine shared ground

Do not fabricate it. Be honest that you are starting from different places.

"I do not think we share the starting assumption here — which might be why we differ."

If The shared ground is used too much and becomes hollow

Use it sparingly — only when it is genuinely true.

SCENARIOS

Negotiation where both sides are defensive

Name the shared goal before stating your position. — "We both want a deal that works. Let me say where I think we can find that."

Team debate where sides are forming

Name what everyone agrees on to shift the dynamic. — "Before we get into the disagreement — I think we all agree on X. Everything else is how."

Presenting a different view to a senior stakeholder

Open with the shared goal. Then present your alternative. — "I am arguing for the same outcome you are. My concern is that this path does not get us there."

Conflict with a close colleague or partner

Name the shared relationship goal before the specific disagreement. — "We both want this to work. That is why I need to say something about it."

WORKED EXAMPLE

Without the technique

You: (in team meeting) I don't think this approach works at all.

(Room goes quiet; energy drops; people become guarded)

With the technique

You: The goal here is exactly right — we need faster delivery. I want to offer a different route to get there.

Team: OK — what are you thinking?

COMMON MISTAKES

The drive-by agreement

Sounds like: 'Totally agree. Anyway, here's why that won't work.'

Better: 'I agree the churn risk is the priority. Here is where I differ on tackling it.'

Manufactured common ground

Sounds like: 'We're all on the same page really, deep down.'

Better: If you cannot name real shared ground, say so: 'I think we start from different assumptions — worth checking that first.'

Agreement that swallows the disagreement

Sounds like: Five minutes of alignment, then: 'so, just minor thoughts really.'

Better: 'That is the common ground. Now the difference — and it is not minor.'

Erasing the agreement with 'but'

Sounds like: 'You're right, but that's not the point.'

Better: 'You are right about X. And it is X that takes me to a different answer.'

Agreement deployed only tactically

Sounds like: (Common ground appears only when you want something.)

Better: Name genuine agreement routinely, so it reads as honesty rather than technique.

READING THE ROOM

Signs it is working

- The conversation stays collaborative even while you disagree.
- The other person does not feel attacked.
- Your disagreement is taken more seriously because it comes after agreement.
- You feel genuine rather than tactical.

Signs to adjust

- The shared ground sounds manufactured.
- You spend so long on agreement that your disagreement is lost.
- You use 'we agree' to avoid saying what you actually think.
- The other person sees through the formula and calls it out.

WHEN NOT TO USE

- When a harmful or unethical direction requires speed of objection over tone.
- When you have already agreed in principle and additional agreement feels performative.
- In one-on-one contexts where the group dynamic element is absent — consider TC001 instead.

RECOVERY LINES

Best line: 'That came out as if I oppose the whole plan. I do not — my issue is one piece of it.'

- "I jumped straight to the disagreement — let me back up to what I agree with first."
- "That came out as if I oppose the whole plan. I do not — my issue is one piece of it."
- "I said 'I agree, but' and did not mean the first half. Honestly, we differ — let me say where."
- "I have been agreeing so hard I never said my actual concern. Here it is."
- "We are arguing as if we want different things. I do not think we do."
- "Let me separate this properly: what we share, and the one place we split."

TECHNIQUE CHAINS

Team debate chain

Name the shared goal -> build it briefly -> mark the turn -> state the difference

Everyone here wants the release out before December.

And nobody wants a repeat of the summer rollback.

Where I differ from the current plan is on scope.

I would cut the reporting module and ship the rest on time.

Senior pushback chain

Grant their premise -> validate the concern -> diverge clearly -> invite response

You are right that we cannot afford another delay.

The worry about credibility with the board is fair.

My disagreement is that shipping broken damages that credibility more.

Tell me where that logic loses you.

RELATED TECHNIQUES

TC007 — Disagreement Without Contempt

Disagreement Without Contempt governs how the difference itself is worded once the shared ground has earned it a hearing.

TC016 — Validation Without Agreement

Validation Without Agreement is the neighbouring move for when you understand their position but cannot honestly agree with any of it.

TC014 — Validate the Concern

Validate the Concern applies the same sequencing to objections — legitimacy first, answer second.

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Find the shared goal

In one disagreement today, identify the goal you both share before stating your position.

Day 2 — Name it aloud

In one conversation, explicitly say: 'We both want X' before stating your counter-position.

Day 3 — Genuine vs manufactured

Check that your agreement is real. If it is not, do not use it.

Day 4 — Keep the disagreement clear

After naming the shared ground, state your difference clearly — do not let the agreement swallow your position.

Day 5 — Use in a negotiation

Use the technique in one situation where you are on opposing sides of something.

Day 6 — Notice the tone

In one use of this technique, notice how the tone of the conversation changes after you name shared ground.

Day 7 — Calibration

Were your disagreements received better? Did any shared ground feel hollow? Did your position still land?

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I identify genuine shared ground before stating my difference?
- Was the agreement specific — not generic?
- Did I state my disagreement clearly after the shared ground?
- Did the conversation feel collaborative rather than adversarial?
- Did I avoid using the agreement to avoid disagreeing?
- Was my agreement genuine rather than performative?
- Did the other person recognise the shared ground as real?